

Congressional Retirements Over Two Centuries

Two centuries of members leaving the House, and the one thing the record will not say

84-355 Democracy's Data

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Of the 259 people who held a seat in the House of Representatives during the Congress that met in 1841, 198 were gone by the next one. That is 76 percent of the chamber, re-placed in a single stroke, and it was not a scandal or a realignment or a war. It was an ordinary decade in an institution where serving in Congress was a temporary condition, like jury duty.

A century and a half later, in the Congress that met in 1987, the same number was 36 members out of 441 – 8.2 percent. The House had stopped emptying.

That much is a familiar story with a familiar name. What is less familiar, and what this chapter is actually about, is the mechanism. **When a member of the modern House leaves, it is usually not because anyone beat them.** Between 2004 and 2022, 790 members left the House. 507 of them – 64 percent – never stood on a ballot they could have lost.

01 Where the evidence comes from, and what it refuses to say

Three files are stacked here, and they are not equally good, which is the first thing to say about them.

Source	What	Covering	Kind
Voteview member file	Every member of every Congress	1789 to 2025	Compiled by researchers, out of roll calls
FEC, <i>Federal Elections</i>	Every House candidate, with primary and general votes	2004 to 2022	A federal agency's own publication
Brookings, <i>Vital Statistics on Congress</i>	Retirements, primary defeats, general defeats, counted	1946 to 2024	Compiled from other people's counts

The **Voteview** file is the spine. It carries one row per member per Congress back to the First, with a chamber, a state, a district and a party, and it is the standard machine-readable form of the congressional membership record. From it, one fact is available for 118 consecutive Congresses without any inference at all: a person served in Congress *N* and did not serve in Congress *N+1*. They left.

What the file cannot say is why, and no membership record ever could. Leaving is recorded; the reason is not a field.

It is worth being clear about what kind of object that spine is, because it arrives looking more official than it is. No agency publishes a machine-readable roster of everyone who has ever served in Congress. Voteview is a research project, built at UCLA over decades, and its raw material is roll-call votes; the membership table is a by-product of needing to know whose vote each one was. Somebody had to reconcile two centuries of names into one person per row, assign identifiers where the government supplies none, and code a party for members who served before the parties had settled names. All of that was done on judgment, before this chapter opened the file. It arrived usable because somebody else did the work, which is a debt and not a complaint.

The debt comes with terms. Voteview's identifier is not a person: when a member changes party in the middle of a Congress the project issues them a *new* one, rather than amending the row they have.

Keyed on that number, Ralph Hall of Texas leaves the House halfway through the 108th and a stranger takes his seat. So does Parker Griffith of Alabama in the 111th, who then went on to be refused the Republican nomination six months later. The file offers a false departure and a real one within a year of each other, and marks them the same way.

There are 16 such rows. The build keys on the Biographical Directory's identifier instead, which survives a switch, and drops the duplicate. Nothing in the file warns that any of this is necessary; the convention is documented nowhere the reader will look, and the only symptom is a departure count that comes out slightly too high.

The **Federal Election Commission's** biennial compilation supplies the missing fact, for the years it covers. It reports, candidate by candidate, the primary vote, the runoff vote and the general-election vote for every House race, compiled from the official canvasses of the state election officials. Put it beside the membership file and each departing member falls into one of four places:

What the files show	What it is called
Not on any House ballot	Did not seek re-election
On the primary ballot, not nominated	Denied renomination
Nominated, lost in November	Defeated in the general election
Nominated, won	Re-elected

The first of those four is a residual: the category for what is left over, everything not caught by the others. Residuals are where the trouble is.

Four very different people sit in it together, and they look identical. One announced a graceful retirement. One resigned under indictment. One died in August. And one quit rather than face a challenger they expected to lose to.

Deaths can be pulled out, because the file records a death year, and so can members who ran for the Senate, because they appear in the same FEC compilation on the Senate side. What is left over is still not "retirement" in any sense that means *chose to stop*. It is **did not appear on a ballot**, and the distinction between choosing to leave and leaving before being pushed is not in any of these files, because it was never in any document.

The obvious place to look for primary results is the Clerk of the House's *Statistics of the Congressional Election*, which another chapter in this book parses out of the Clerk's own

PDFs. It does not have them and never has. Its title page says what it is: the vote cast for each *nominee*. Every edition from 1946 to 2024 was searched. The word “primary” appears in a handful of them, and in every case it is a footnote about Louisiana, whose nonpartisan blanket primary is that state’s general election.

The pre-2000 editions are photographic scans with no text in them at all and were checked by eye. **The FEC compilation is a different publication with a different remit, and for congressional primaries it is the only federal source there is.**

It also stops. The FEC has not published a 2024 edition, and asking its document server for one is instructive. The address `fec.gov/documents/5675/federaelections2024.xlsx` returns a success code, eight megabytes, and the 2022 report as a PDF. That server addresses files by a number and ignores the filename entirely. A build script that trusted the status code would have shipped the wrong year under the right name.

The **Brookings** table is the weakest of the three and the longest. It counts retirements, primary defeats and general defeats for every election from 1946 to 2024, and it is assembled from the Biographical Directory, *CQ Almanac* and the *National Journal* rather than derived from returns. It is here because it reaches back seventy-eight years, because nothing built from primary documents can, and because it gives the derivation above something to be wrong against.

02 The column that stops, and the file that does not mention it

Before any of that can be joined to anything, the membership record has to be read, and it contains a trap that no amount of care about the FEC would catch. Here are two Alabama members in the 114th Congress and the same two in the 115th, out of `HSall_members.csv`:

Column	What it is	Row 47741	Row 47742	Row 48283	Row 48284
congress	the numbered two-year Congress	114	114	115	115
chamber	House, Senate or President	House	House	House	House
icpsr	the member’s permanent ID, kept across every Congress	20301	21102	20301	21102
state_abbrev	two-letter postal abbreviation	AL	AL	AL	AL
district_code	district number	3	7	3.0	7.0
occupancy	which occupant of the seat this is in this Congress	0	0	(empty)	(empty)
last_means	how the member reached office — election, special election, appointment	1	1	(empty)	(empty)
bioguide_id	Biographical Directory ID	R000575	S001185	R000575	S001185
bioname	name, as last, first middle	ROGERS, Mike Dennis	SEWELL, Terri	ROGERS, Mike Dennis	SEWELL, Terri

Same men, same seats, consecutive Congresses, and **two columns quietly empty** in the second pair. `occupancy` records whether a member was the first, second or third per-

son to hold that seat in that Congress. It is the only evidence anywhere in this file that somebody left in the middle of a term. `last_means` recorded whether a member arrived by general election or by special election. Both stop:

Congress	Share of House rows with occupancy filled
110	0.989
112	1.000
113	1.000
114	1.000
115	0.000
116	0.000
117	0.000
118	0.000
119	0.000

Filled for every House row through the 114th and for none after it, and **nothing in the file announces it**. No footnote, no marker, no change of type. The cells are simply empty. A build that reached for `occupancy` to count mid-term replacements would run clean, report zero of them from 2017 onward, and describe a House in which nobody has ever been replaced between elections.

That is why the denominator in this chapter is what it is. The denominator is the bottom number every rate here is divided by. The natural choice for a chapter about leaving would be the class the last general election seated: 435 people, one per seat, which is exactly what `occupancy` would let you isolate. It is not available for the recent Congresses this chapter cares most about. So the denominator is instead **every person who held a House seat during a Congress**: 445 people in the 118th, not 435. That is a defensible unit and it is not the one Brookings uses, which is one of the reasons the two series in this chapter run close without ever quite meeting.

One more difference in those rows is worth catching, because it is the kind of thing that breaks a join silently. `district_code` is 3 in the 114th and 3.0 in the 115th. The value did not change; its written form did, halfway through a single file, and any key pasted together out of state and district as text would stop matching at exactly that Congress. **The join would not fail. It would return fewer rows**, quietly, and every count built on it would be too small by however many members happened to sit after 2017.

Here is what a member becomes once the membership file and the ten workbooks have been put together — one row per sitting member per election cycle:

Congress	State abbrev	District code	Election year	On house ballot	Denied	Ge win	Outcome
114	AL	3	2016	TRUE	FALSE	TRUE	re-elected
115	AL	3	2018	TRUE	FALSE	TRUE	re-elected

`outcome` is the column the chapter is about and it exists in neither source. It is assembled from three facts: did this member appear on a House ballot at all, did they win the nomination, did they win in November. The first of those three is doing most of the work.

A member who is simply *absent* from the FEC file did not stand, and 507 of the 790 departures in this window are that: **not an event recorded anywhere, but the absence of one.**

03 Two files that share no identifier

Joining the membership record to the candidate record is the whole method, and the two have no key in common. The FEC has its own candidate identifiers; Voteview has ICPSR numbers; neither appears in the other's file. So the join is built on state and name, and names do not cooperate.

What breaks	Example
Compound surnames split differently	FEC "Schultz" against Voteview "WASSERMAN SCHULTZ"
Suffixes	"Conyers, Jr." against "CONYERS"
Accents	Voteview writes LUJÁN with an acute
Errors in the official federal file	"Synder", "Gallegry", "Alderholt", "Norcross", "Sherril"
Two members, one state, one surname, one initial	Linda and Loretta Sanchez of California

The escape from most of that is not a cleverer name rule. It is an identifier that already exists: **the FEC gives each candidate a permanent number, and it persists across cycles.** Match a name once, in a year where the name is unambiguous, and the number carries the match into every later file.

That is what rescues the two Sanchezes. They ran in renumbered districts in 2012, so state, surname, first initial and district number all fail at once. Their identifiers had already been matched in 2010, when the district numbers still agreed. Of 3,936 incumbent candidacies, 3931 of 3938 (99.82%) were matched; 2,731 came from the identifier and only 18 needed a rule looser than an exact surname.

Two things then go wrong in the other direction, and both are worth naming because both would have produced a confident wrong answer.

The FEC's incumbent marker is not always right. The 2022 file marks Tim Reichert, a Republican candidate in Colorado's 7th district, as the incumbent. He had never held the seat; it was open that year because Ed Perlmutter retired. Every marked incumbent here is therefore required to appear in the membership record for that Congress, and 7 rows failed the test and were dropped. The same test catches former members trying to come back, whom the file also marks. Carol Shea-Porter and Joe Garcia both lost in 2014 and both ran again in 2016, carrying an incumbent marker they were not entitled to.

The marker is also sometimes simply missing. Every row of Michigan's 7th district in the 2006 file has an empty incumbent column, including Joe Schwarz, who was the sitting member and lost the Republican primary. Searching the unmarked candidates by identifier recovers 6 such members. Searching them by *name* would recover Schwarz. It would also find, in the 2016 file, one Joe McDermott of Washington's 7th district. That is not Jim McDermott of Washington's 7th district, and the file would record a sitting member denied renomination.

A third trap is smaller and more alarming. Several party cells in these workbooks end in a non-breaking space, which is not a space as far as any ordinary trimming function is concerned. In the 2016 Kansas file Roger Marshall's party is R followed by one of those char-

acters, and Tim Huelskamp's is R/W. After ordinary cleaning the two sit in two different Republican primaries in the same district, each unopposed. Huelskamp lost that primary by fourteen thousand votes.

04 The long fall

With the join built, the simplest question can be asked of every Congress since the first.

Period	Share who did not return
1789-1830	42.7%
1831-1870	55.1%
1871-1900	43.8%
1901-1940	26.0%
1941-1980	18.4%
1981-2024	15.0%

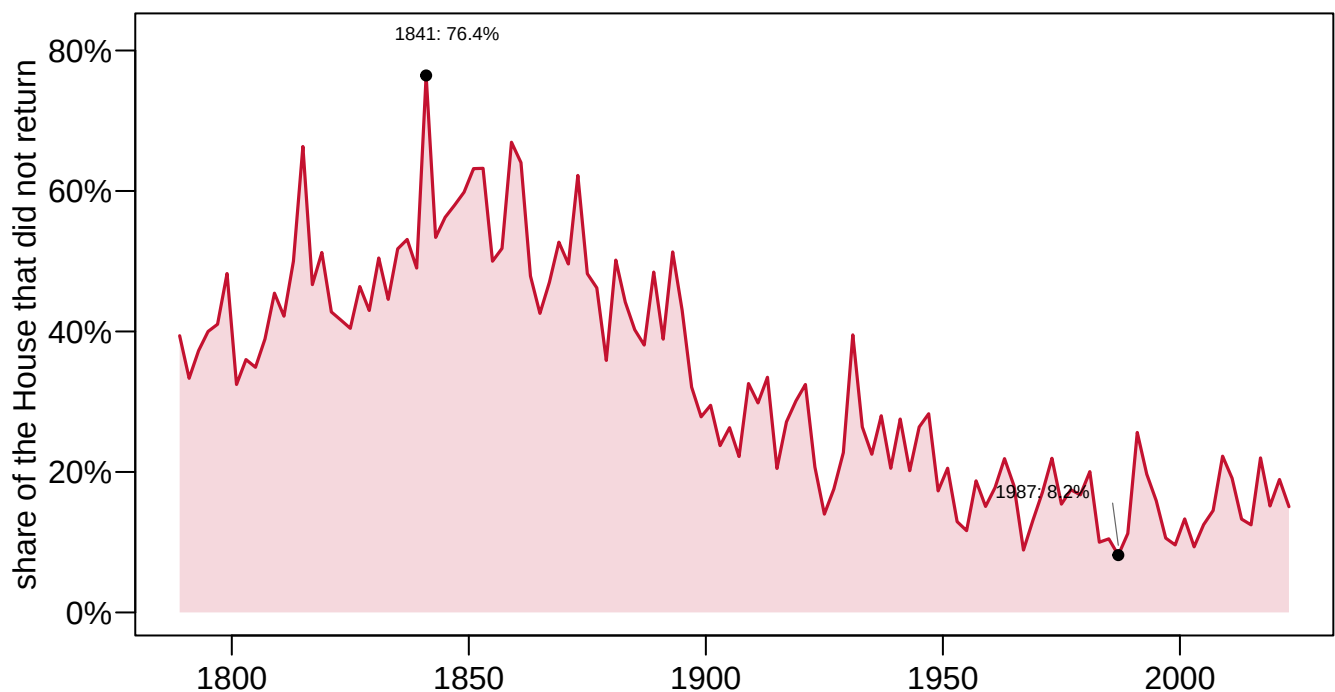


Figure 1. The share of the House that did not come back, every Congress from 1789 to 2023. Each point is one Congress: the number of people who held a House seat during it and did not hold one in the next, divided by the number who held one. The peak is 1841 at 76.4 percent; the floor since 1900 is 1987 at 8.2 percent. The average has fallen from 42.7 percent in the first four decades to 15.0 percent since 1980.

The shape is the professionalization of Congress, which **Polsby (1968)** described as the House acquiring boundaries, an internal career structure and universalistic rules – an institution rather than a way station. Members stopped going home because there came to be something worth staying for. Committee seniority made a long career valuable, and a long career made the House worth organizing around long careers.

That much is settled. The question this chapter is about starts where that one finishes: **once turnover has fallen to fifteen percent, who are the fifteen percent?**

05 The exits, sorted

Outcome	Members	Share
Re-elected	3,653	82.2%
Did not seek re-election	387	8.7%
Defeated in the general election	225	5.1%
Ran for the Senate	102	2.3%
Denied renomination	58	1.3%
Died in office	18	0.4%

Those are the 4,443 member-cycles in the ten elections from 2004 to 2022: every person who held a House seat during a Congress, and what became of them at the election that followed.

Four out of five came back. Of the 790 who did not, the two routes that involve losing an election account for 283, and everything else – 507 members, 64 percent of all departures – accounts for the rest. The modal way to leave the House of Representatives is to stop being a candidate for it.

Before you read on, commit to a number. In the ten elections above, 790 members left the House and 283 of them were beaten by voters. Those defeats split two ways: beaten in November by the other party, or refused renomination by their own. **How many of the 283 were refused renomination by their own party?** Write down a count, or a share of 283, before you look at Figure 2.

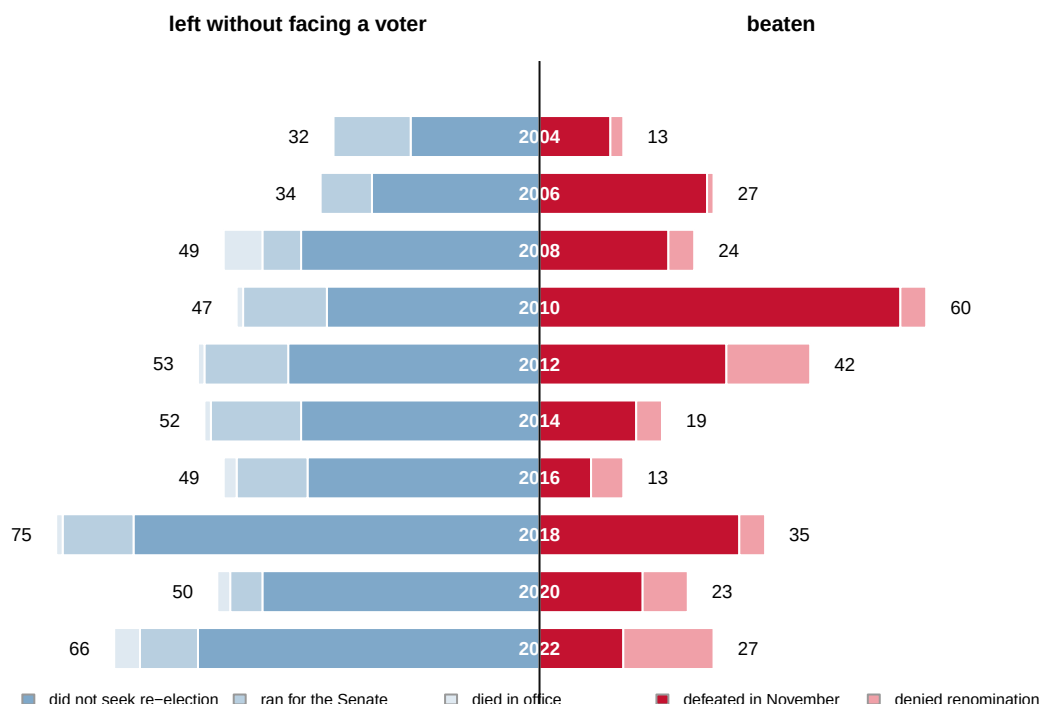


Figure 2. Every House departure from 2004 to 2022, split at the line. To the left of each year, members who left without standing on a ballot they could lose; to the right, members somebody defeated. Across the ten elections the left side totals 507 and the right side 283. Of the 283 defeats, 225 were general elections and 58 were primaries – 20 percent of all defeats, and 1.3 percent of all member-cycles.

Most readers put the primary share somewhere around a third, because primaries are where the attention is. It is 58 of 283. A sitting member of the House is roughly 3.9 times more likely to be beaten in November by the other party than to be refused renomination by their own. Both together are a minority of departures.

The wrong lesson to draw is that the House is safe. The right one is that the mechanism of turnover has moved. Compare the earliest and latest quarter centuries in the Brookings series:

	1946–1970, per election	2000–2024, per election
Retired	28.2	38.0
Defeated in a primary	8.5	5.8
Defeated in November	31.3	17.5

The two lines swapped. In the first postwar quarter century an average of 31 members a cycle were thrown out in November and 28 left of their own accord. In the most recent quarter century it is 17 thrown out and 38 leaving. **The chamber did not become more stable so much as it changed who does the removing** – and increasingly nobody does.

That is the same finding the *house-competition* chapter reaches from the other side. Where a district's November result is a foregone conclusion, the general election cannot remove anybody, and the seat empties only when its occupant decides to go.

06 Do retirements cluster?

The folk theory in Washington is that they do. Members can see a wave coming, a minority with no prospect of a majority is a miserable place to work, and the announcements come in a run. It is a testable claim, and the Brookings series is long enough to test it.

The first test is the redistricting cycle. Every ten years the maps are redrawn and the first election on the new lines is the one held in a year ending in 2. A member whose district has been dismantled has an obvious reason to leave.

Election	Retirements	Primary defeats	General defeats
First on a new map (years ending in 2)	41.8	12.0	19.8
All other years	34.0	5.2	23.4

Retirements barely move, and primary defeats more than double. That is the opposite of the folk theory, and there is a simple explanation. A new map does not usually destroy a member's district so much as put two members into one. Two members in one district produce a primary, not a retirement. The clustering is real. It is in the wrong column.

The second test is the wave. If retirements anticipate defeat, a party that loses many members to retirement should lose many seats at the same election.

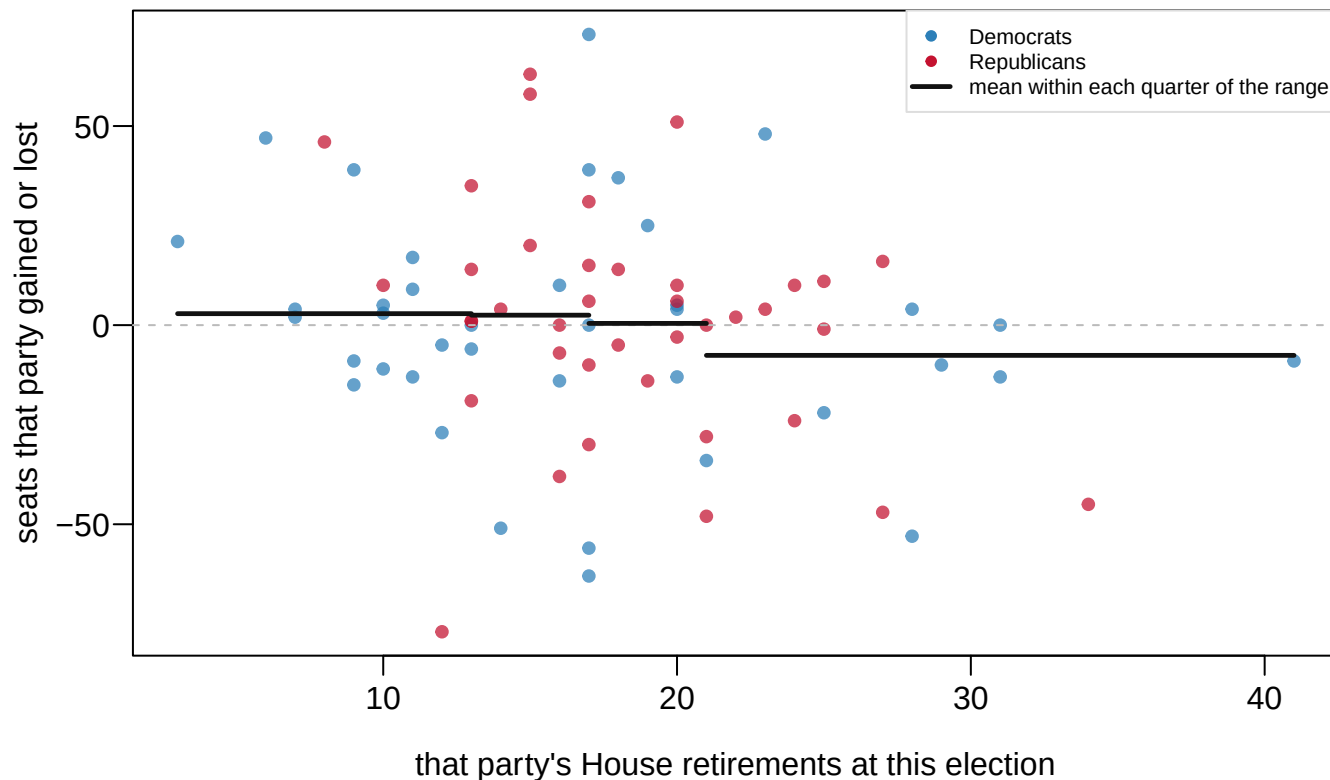


Figure 3. Retirements against seats won or lost, one point per party per election, 1946 to 2022. Retirement counts are from Brookings; the seat change is computed from the Voteview membership file, by counting each party's members in one Congress and in the next. The correlation across all 78 points is -0.22 , and a straight line through them explains 5 percent of the variation. The horizontal bars are the mean seat change within each quarter of the retirement range: 2.9, 2.5, 0.4 and -7.6 seats.

The signal exists and it is almost entirely in the top quarter. Below about 21 retirements, a party's retirement count says nothing at all about how the election will go. The three lower bars sit on either side of zero without a pattern. Above it, the average party loses 7.6 seats. A wave of retirements is a signal of a bad year for that party, but only when it is a wave. The relationship is far too loose to be the forecasting tool it is often treated as on television.

Notice also what the figure cannot distinguish, and it is the same thing that has been missing since the first page. **A member who retires because they expect to lose and a member who retires because they are seventy-four and tired of flying to Washington produce the same row.** The correlation in Figure 3 fits members reading the polls. It fits equally well with the party having recruited badly in the same years, for the same underlying reasons. Nothing in these files chooses between the two.

07 The other half of an identity

The *officeholder-age* chapter of this book reports that the median member of Congress has aged substantially since 1970, and that the aging comes almost entirely from members *arriving* older rather than from members *staying* longer. That is a claim about tenure, and tenure is arithmetically the inverse of the departures counted here: if members are not leaving faster, they are staying the same length of time.

Period	Share not returning	Mean years served so far
1962-1980	16.7%	8.9
2006-2023	17.0%	9.3

Both numbers are flat. Across 109 Congresses the correlation between the share of the House that does not return and the average time its members have already served is - 0.87. That is strongly negative, as it must be, since the two are measuring the same career from opposite ends. The two chapters were built from the same Voteview file by different derivations, and they agree: **members of the modern House do not serve longer than members of the 1960s House did. They arrive older.**

08 What this evidence will bear

The strengths are narrow and real. The membership series is a full enumeration rather than a sample, it is 118 Congresses long, and the fact it rests on – served then, did not serve now – requires no judgment from anybody. The election series is a federal agency's compilation of the states' own canvasses, read here from the published workbooks rather than inherited second-hand. The classification it produces was checked against two independent hand-built counts. On primary defeats, this build and Brookings and the Giroux tracker agree exactly in 7 of the 10 elections and are never more than one apart.

The weaknesses begin with the residual and do not end there.

"Did not seek re-election" is a category of ignorance. It contains a member who wanted to leave and a member who ran out of options, and this chapter cannot separate them. Telling them apart would need a record of what somebody intended, and no agency keeps

one. Every sentence above about retirement being a choice is therefore a sentence about a category that also holds the people who were pushed.

Two years of the modern series are missing. The FEC has published no 2024 compilation, so the four-way sorting stops at 2022 while the membership series runs to 2023. The Brookings column covers 2024 and is not built from returns.

The denominator moved under the file. Voteview's occupancy field recorded whether a member was the first or second person to hold a seat in a Congress. It is filled in for the 1st Congress through the 114th, and empty for every row after that. So after 2015 the class a general election seated cannot be told apart from the members who arrived mid-term. The denominator used throughout is everyone who held a seat during a Congress: 445 people in the Congress that met in 2023, rather than the 435 seats they sat in. Brookings counts the other way, which is one reason the two series are close without being identical.

Death and resignation are approximations. The membership file records a death year, not a date, so a member who left in January and died in November of the same year cannot be told from one who died in office. The rule used here is deliberately conservative and therefore undercounts.

Two centuries are not one series. A departure in 1841 and a departure in 2021 are counted identically, and they are not the same event. Before the Seventeenth Amendment a House member's route upward ran through a state legislature, and districts were often multi-member. The parties themselves dissolved and reformed twice inside the steepest part of Figure 1.

And the largest limit is the one the chapter opened on. **This is a study of 4,443 careers, and it never observes a decision.** It observes ballots and rosters. Anyone who wants to know why the House empties the way it does now will have to go and ask. The people worth asking are precisely the ones with a reason to give whichever answer reads best.

09 Sources

Data

- Lewis, J. B., Poole, K., Rosenthal, H., Boche, A., Rudkin, A. and Sonnet, L. *Voteview: Congressional Roll-Call Votes Database*, member file `HSa11_members.csv`. <https://voteview.com/> — retrieved 2026-08-11, 51,062 rows, Congresses 1 to 119.
- Federal Election Commission, *Federal Elections*, biennial compilations for 2004 through 2022. <https://www.fec.gov/introduction-campaign-finance/election-results-and-voting-information/> — retrieved 2026-08-11, 10 workbooks, 22,156 House candidate rows. Compiled by the Commission from the official canvasses of the state election officials.
- Brookings Institution, *Vital Statistics on Congress*, Chapter 2, edition of April 2026, Table 2-7 (House incumbents retired, defeated or re-elected, 1946–2024) and Table 2-9 (House and Senate retirements by party). <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/vital-statistics-on-congress/>
- Giroux, G. *Members of Congress Defeated For Renomination, 1966–2026*. Publicly shared spreadsheet; used in this chapter only as an independent check on the primary-defeat counts, and discussed at length in the *primary-defeats* chapter. <https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1X97S6hUby6PPHAMoEwvAxkAUo8EUwLk8xMosx4hVd8c/>

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`compare.csv`, `departures.csv`, `exits.csv`, `exits_by_year.csv`, `vsoc.csv`,
`vsoc_party.csv`, `age_by_congress.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `exits_by_year.csv` splits every departure into re-elected, defeated, denied, died, or not running. Compute the share for each. Which is the main way members leave?
- `departures.csv` runs back to the first Congress with `pct_left`. Follow it. When did serving in the House stop being something people did briefly?
- `age_by_congress.csv` has `median_age` and `pct_70plus`. Plot both across the series. Is Congress getting older faster than the country?
- `compare.csv` shows three sources counting the same departures and disagreeing. Pick a year with a gap and work out which source you would trust and why.

Academic literature

- Polsby, N. W. (1968). "The Institutionalization of the U.S. House of Representatives." *American Political Science Review* 62(1): 144–168.

Further reading

- Mayhew, D. R. (1974). *Congress: The Electoral Connection*. Yale University Press.
- Jacobson, G. C. and Carson, J. L. (2019). *The Politics of Congressional Elections*. 10th ed. Rowman & Littlefield.

How the figures were made

Every source above was fetched, the ten FEC workbooks parsed and joined to the membership file, giving the tables this document reads. It is also the build for the `primary-defeats` chapter, which asks a different question of the same derivation. It records every URL, the date each was retrieved, the byte counts that came back, and the validation results reproduced in `checks.csv`. Every number printed above is computed from the files it wrote, at the moment this document was rendered.

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original sources, without any starting files. Please do the following and show your work.

THE FIRST SOURCE. Voteview's congressional member file:

https://voteview.com/static/data/out/members/HSall_members.csv

One CSV, about 6 MB. Each row is one member serving in one Congress, 1789 to the present – the standard compilation of congressional membership. No account or key is needed.

THE SECOND SOURCE. Federal Election Commission, "Federal Elections", the agency's biennial compilation of official results. One Excel workbook per cycle, 2004 through 2024, each pinned by a document id, for example <https://www.fec.gov/documents/5675/federalections2024.xlsx>. It carries primary, runoff and general vote totals for every House candidate, with an incumbent flag – the only primary-election source compiled by a federal agency.

THE THIRD SOURCE. Brookings Institution, "Vital Statistics on Congress", Chapter 2 workbook:

<https://www.brookings.edu/wp-content/uploads/2026/04/Chpt-2.xlsx>
Table 2-7 counts House incumbents retired, defeated or reelected, 1946-2024 – an independent compilation to check against.

HOW TO FETCH THE FEC WORKBOOKS. The sheet names differ from edition to edition, and one of them ships a typo the agency itself made – the 2012 House sheet is titled "Resuts", not "Results". Find sheets by matching their names loosely, never by assuming a fixed label.

WHAT TO BUILD.

1. From Voteview: every sitting House member in each Congress since 2003, and whether they appear again after the next election.
2. From the FEC workbooks: for each member who left, the route out – retired, beaten in a primary, or beaten in November.
3. The primary-defeat count per cycle, set beside Brookings Table 2-7.

CHECK YOUR WORK. The copies this book used were fetched in August 2026. If your rebuild matches them, you should find:

- 51,062 rows in the Voteview file, covering Congresses 1 to 119
- 22,156 House candidate rows in the FEC workbooks for 2004-2022
- 58 primary defeats over 2004-2022 by this derivation; Brookings counts 61, never differing from it by more than 1 in any year

Voteview regenerates its file continuously and each new Congress adds rows; a higher row count or a top Congress past 119 means the file grew, not that you made an error.